

WHAT YOU NEED TO KNOW: PARTNERSHIP

Background

Round 2 of The Extreme Heat and Community Resilience Program will fund Early and Advanced Infrastructure projects to mitigate the impacts of extreme heat. Project proposals for Round 2 must demonstrate how they advance the Extreme Heat Program Values of Harm Reduction, Collaborative Partnerships, Belonging, and Lasting Community Benefits.

Understanding Partnership as a Program Value

Successful applicants recognize that effective solutions require both community knowledge and implementation capacity. Communities most affected by extreme heat bring critical lived experience and insight into local conditions, while public agencies and other institutions provide the authority, resources, and scale needed to deliver infrastructure. This value emphasizes intentional, complementary partnerships and shared decision-making, ensuring that projects are both grounded in community realities and positioned for successful implementation and long-term support. Applications selected for funding will demonstrate not only a strong and finalized partnership, but also an understanding of each partner's relevant expertise and strengths and a clear narrative of how each partner will contribute to the project.

What does Partnership look like in a project?

Strong applications that depict a project with a commitment to Partnership provide a thoughtful justification for each project partner's position based on factors like areas of expertise, community ties, past experience with similar projects, and others. Consider including the following information in your Full Application for a strong Partnership narrative:

- **Why** were these specific project partners (Co-Applicants, Contributors, and/or Supporters) chosen, aside from convenience?
- **What** does each partner bring to the table that strengthens the proposed project?
- **How** will project tasks be divided among partners, and how did you make this decision? What attributes of each partner lend themselves to assigned tasks?
- **Where** are partners located? Do they have previous experience and/or relationships from working in the community?
- **What** existing community partners exist, and will they be included in the project? If so, **how**?
- **How** will you support the continuation of these partnerships during and after the grant term?

Elements of Project Partnership

The following table depicts different elements of Partnership as given or required in the Extreme Heat Program Full Guidelines.

	Lead Applicant	Co-Applicant	Contributor(s) (if involved)	Supporter(s) (if involved)
Required?	Yes	Yes*	No	No
Receives grant funds?	Yes, as grantee	Yes, through Lead Applicant	Yes, through Lead Applicant	No
Must have workplan tasks?	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
Must have budget items?	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
Requires letter of support?	No	Yes	No	Yes
Application responsibilities	-Coordinate team members to prepare proposal and gather documentation -Submit Pre-Application Interest Form -Submit Full Application	-Provide Co-Applicant's key activities, detailed tasks, letter of support, and costs to Lead Applicant for use in the full application and workplan	-Project workplan and budget should include high-level description of activities and cost, but do not require detailed tasks or budget justification for application	-Provide a Letter of Support to Lead Applicant to include with application
Post-award responsibilities	-Enter into grant agreement with the State to receive funds -Subgrant funds to project partners -Serve as point of contact with the Governor's Office of Land Use and Climate Innovation (LCI) -Lead grant administration and project implementation	-Sign Partnership Agreement with Lead Applicant -Implement grant activities and support grant implementation as outlined in Partnership Agreement	-Develop and refine tasks, deliverables, and costs over the project period - Implement grant activities as outlined in refined workplan	-May participate in some project activities without receiving funds

*Tribes are not required to have a Co-Applicant. See program guidelines for additional details.

Prompts to consider

Although the following questions are not included in the Full Application, considering them during application development can help you to understand and plan for Partnership throughout the application and planning processes.

- Are partner roles, responsibilities, and budget allocations clearly defined and reflective of each organization's strengths?
- What existing community partnerships could be integrated into the community engagement process to support us in ensuring the proposed infrastructure will be designed and built effectively to serve the most vulnerable?
- What opportunities are there to build partner capacity (e.g., workforce training, knowledge transfers, etc.) that will strengthen our ability to sustain and grow heat resilience efforts?
- Does each partner have a clear understanding of their roles and responsibilities during construction?
- How will partners maintain communication and division of duties before, during, and after the project implementation phase?
- How will partnerships developed through this project support the development of future heat resilience initiatives?
- Are there any opportunities to expand the partnership network to include new organizations for future phases of work?
- What specific partnership elements made this project successful, and how can they be replicated?
- How can we best highlight and discuss lessons learned for future partnership efforts in the required grant reporting and peer learning materials?

Where and how to include Partnership in the Full Application

Partnership should be emphasized throughout both the Full Application and the project process. For a competitive application, include partnership in the following application areas:

- **Project overview narrative:** Ensure that this narrative includes each partner's relevance to the proposed project.
- **Partnership questions:** This section is the best place to talk about your Partnership plans in detail. Full Applications are considered strong when the Lead Applicant clearly and thoughtfully discusses the reasons behind partner selection that go beyond convenience. How does each partner strengthen the project in unique ways? What experience does each partner have with extreme heat, vulnerable populations, or other elements of the project and program? Do any of the partners have existing ties to the community? What experience does each partner have with the project tasks for which they will be responsible?
- **Project workplan and budget:** In the workplan and budget, activities and costs can be designated to the Lead Applicant, Co-Applicant(s), and Contributor(s), if any. For Early Infrastructure, a minimum of 8% of the total budget must go to partners. For Advanced Infrastructure, a minimum of 6% of the total budget must go to partners.

Partnership done well: an example from an Extreme Heat Round 1 grantee

In Round 1 of the Extreme Heat Program, North Coast Opportunities Inc., Middletown Rancheria of Pomo Indians, and the City of Clearlake came together to propose the Cooling and Heating Homes with Innovative Low-Impact Living (SolarCHILL) project. The SolarCHILL project focuses on the installation of solar-powered mini-split cooling and heating units for vulnerable households, training of residents in solar panel installation and maintenance, and community education campaigns. The Lead Applicant, North Coast Opportunities (NCO), is a community-based organization that collaborated with the Tribal Nation of Middletown Rancheria as a Co-Applicant and the City of Clearlake as a Supporter to jointly shape the initiative and ensure that the effort aligned with the region's existing plans and actions concentrated on improving the community's adaptive capacity.

What they did well

Clarify Partner Roles and Responsibilities – In designing their partnership structure, the SolarCHILL project team had a clear sense of each entity's duties. NCO manages overall grant administration, coordinates the workforce development initiative, oversees contractor relationships, and leads data collection and reporting. As a Co-Applicant, the Middletown Rancheria Tribal Nation gathers community input, identifies potential project participants and mini-split recipients, and organizes community events. Both partners work together to shape the implementation of the project through direct engagement with the community to design processes that ensure the most vulnerable households benefit from these limited resources, while also building extreme heat awareness to support future expansion.

Support Capacity Building – The workforce training component of SolarCHILL was modeled after NCO's existing Building Up Individuals and Local Development (BUILD) program, which aims to provide vulnerable populations with construction training opportunities and work experiences. To ensure the long-term sustainability of solar workforce programming in Lake County, the program trains participants from both within and outside the Tribe to lead the installation of mini splits funded through this grant and in future projects.

[Click here for a news release about this example project!](#)

[Click here to see how the project is continuing!](#)



The Solar CHILL project installs solar-powered mini-split units for vulnerable households in Lake County.